

A Guide to the Program Credential Development and Approval Process

By Cate Weir, Chelsea VanHorn Stinnett, Matthew L. McClellan, and Belkis Choiseul-Praslin

Introduction

Postsecondary education (PSE) programs for students with intellectual disability should be built around a course of study leading to a meaningful credential. Typically, programs award a non-degree credential available only to students who are attending the program. In addition to or instead of these program-specific credentials, students in these programs may be supported to earn credentials available to all students at their college or university (with and without disability).

In this guide, we focus on the credential that is specifically for students with intellectual disability enrolled in the program. We outline how to develop a robust and comprehensive course of study that culminates in a meaningful credential approved and awarded by the accredited college or university where the program is located.

Credentials from PSE Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability

PSE programs for students with intellectual disability should culminate in a formal acknowledgment of student learning, just like any other postsecondary program. In the early days of college programs for students with intellectual disability, the awarding of credentials was inconsistent and often lacked formal approval from institutions or credentialing entities. Without standardized requirements, such as a specified number of credits or clock hours, students completing the program were not held to the same level of academic achievement. Additionally, there was a lack of comprehensive assessment of student learning, resulting in certificates that often served as verification of attendance rather than meaningful indicators of student achievement.

The Higher Education Opportunity Act (HEOA) of 2008 significantly impacted the field by defining a comprehensive transition and postsecondary (CTP) program for students with intellectual disability.

Postsecondary Education Credentials

When students attend a postsecondary institution, they are typically on a path to earn some sort of credential. A university or college credential is an official document approved by the institution that verifies a student has completed a program of study. Credentials can include certificates, diplomas, degrees, certifications, licenses, and micro-credentials/badges.

Degree

An academic credential awarded by a college or university after a student completes a specific program of study. Degrees are considered the gold standard by employers because they are awarded by accredited institutions that meet rigorous academic standards.

Academic Certificate

A non-degree credential awarded by an educational institution or training provider after a student completes a program of study, including coursework, tests, and other performance evaluations.

License or industry certification

A non-degree credential that is typically awarded by a professional organization or industry group. These credentials signify knowledge and often application of field-specific skills, such as a nursing license or a project management certification.

Micro-credential/badge

A very flexible credential that allows the user to demonstrate their knowledge of a certain topic.

“The program credential is about ensuring our students leave with something tangible that demonstrates their value to employers and society.”

To receive CTP program designation from the US Department of Education, programs must adhere to this definition, which includes essential components like an individualized course of study based on person-centered plans that encompass career development, inclusive academics, independent living skills, and campus engagement. Additionally, the HEOA requires CTP programs to assess student progress and implement a Satisfactory Academic Progress policy (Higher Education Opportunity Act, Pub. L. No. 110-315, 2008).

The HEOA definition of a CTP program also states that students with intellectual disability must spend at least half of their academic time in inclusive college courses or internships alongside students without disabilities (Higher Education Opportunity Act, Pub. L. No. 110-315, 2008). While some programs offer specialized courses for students to focus on foundational, employment, and independent living skills, the HEOA emphasizes maximum inclusivity in all program components. This approach fosters social interaction, personal growth, and the development of practical skills for a successful transition beyond college.

Built on the foundation of the HEOA’s statutory definition and higher education accreditation principles and practices, program accreditation standards have also been developed to enhance the quality of the field at large (Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council, 2024). These standards stipulate that accredited programs must offer a college/university approved credential based on a course of study that meets the CTP program requirements. This ensures that students enrolled in accredited programs receive a recognized credential, acknowledging their academic achievements, career preparation, and personal growth. Not only does this approval speak to the rigor and quality of the credential, but it also strengthens the program’s

standing within the college/university system by providing programming and documentation on par with other academic programs.

With the implementation of standardized requirements and assessment procedures, credentials awarded by these programs hold greater value and credibility.

Current Landscape

The [Think College-College Search Directory](#) shares information on PSE programs for students with intellectual disability. As of March 2025, there were 360 programs listed in the directory. The total number of programs in the college search directory has grown from 313 in 2022 to 360 in March 2025. During this time, the number of programs offering credentials has also risen steadily, with 222 programs offering credentials in 2022 and 276 in 2025. As of March 2025, 160 programs in the College Search Directory report that they offer a credential approved by their institute of higher education (IHE) to students completing their program, which is 58% of all programs that reported offering a credential.

We can glean additional insights from the data reported annually by federally funded model demonstration programs known as Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities, or TPSID programs. The most recent data available indicate that, of the 127 credentials reported by TPSID programs in Year 4 of Cohort 3 (2023–2024), 78% (n = 99) of the credentials were formally approved by the college or university, reflecting strong institutional recognition and enhancing the credentials’ value for students and employers. Furthermore, 43% (n = 54) were aligned with industry-recognized standards, emphasizing a focus on equipping students with credentials that are applicable and valued in the job market, thereby improving employability and job readiness for graduates.

Considerations for Developing a Program Credential

There are several key factors to consider as programs embark on developing a credential that can be approved by their college or university.

Define the Course of Study

The course of study serves as the foundation for the credential awarded by the program, outlining the required academic courses and other activities that students must complete. It must be designed to be flexible enough to accommodate the individual goals of each student, while still providing a consistent expectation for all.

A unique feature of the course of study for programs for students with intellectual disability is that it includes more than just academic requirements. While coursework is a key component of these programs, it also includes independent living and required campus and career development activities. These foundational skills are an essential component of a CTP program credential, as this will prepare students for careers, community living, and a more self-determined life. The course of study also includes experiential learning, such as internships, field experiences, and service-learning projects. These provide students with opportunities to apply their learning in real-world settings and to develop the skills and knowledge they need to be successful in their chosen careers.

Another unique feature is that students may audit college courses and have those courses count toward their program credential. These are counted as credit hour equivalencies. These equivalent credits, earned from audited courses and other normally non-credit activities

taken as part of a program for students with intellectual disabilities, are used to outline the requirements to earn the program credential.

Name and Describe the Credential

The name of a credential should reflect the intended outcomes of a particular course of study. Consider this: If your program is called the “CATS program”, the credential name “CATS Certificate” does not reflect the content a student masters or the skills they develop in the program. However, if students who complete the CATS program earn a “Career Readiness Certificate,” this implies a course of study centered around career preparation experiences. For community employers unaware of the CATS program, the credential name on a resume may be the only opportunity to convey its value, hence the importance of a content-specific name that is descriptive of the program’s goals. This type of descriptive credential name also better aligns with typical naming conventions for other types of postsecondary credentials.

Plan to Assess Student Learning

Programs must assess and evaluate student learning through standard grading procedures, alternative assessment rubrics, or both. It is crucial to have a mechanism to track and assess student progress for every course and learning activity that are part of the course of study. Review this resource, [Example of Grading Rubrics](#), to learn more.

Determine and Articulate the Value of the Credential

While the value of traditional degrees or industry-recognized credentials is widely acknowledged, these new types of credentials may be less understood. Therefore, it is crucial for programs supporting students with intellectual disability to be able to articulate the significance of their certificate. A comprehensive and rigorous course of study that sets high standards for graduation is essential. It is also imperative to help students learn to explain the skills and knowledge they have acquired through the program, enabling them to effectively communicate

The course of study leading to the credential must:

- include all required components (academics, career development, independent living and self-determination)
- be flexible enough to allow for individual choices based on a person-centered plan
- include regular assessment of learning to ensure students are meeting satisfactory progress in all program components
- specify the number of credit hours, equivalent credit hours, or clock hours that are required to earn the credential

their preparedness for employment during job interviews. Given the relative novelty of these credentials, it is important that we clearly define what they represent and outline the competencies and abilities that graduates possess. The Think College Insight Brief, [Articulating the Value of a Credential from a PSE Program for Students with Intellectual Disability](#), offers more on this subject.

Pursuing Institutional Approval of the Credential: Advice from the Field

Once a program has created a course of study with a plan to assess student learning in all components, named the credential, and determined the value of this credential to students, they are ready to apply for the credential to be approved by their college or university.

The authors sought out directors of programs that offered a credential formally approved

by their institution. We conducted interviews to identify the process required to earn institutional approval. The interviewees outlined the steps they went through to guide the program credential through their university's approval process, identifying successful strategies as well as barriers they encountered along the way.

In general, the approval process involves:

- developing a detailed proposal with program goals, curriculum, budget, and proof of compliance with accreditation or institutional policies
- presenting that proposal to Faculty Senate or a curriculum committee
- responding to concerns and perhaps adjusting programmatic operations to align with institutional requirements

Once approved, the program credential will be part of your college or university's academic offerings and students will be awarded an approved and recognized credential upon graduation.

IHE Characteristics	IHE Name	PSE Program Name	Type of Credential
Public 4-year Large R1	University of Georgia	Destination Dawgs: Inclusive Postsecondary Education at UGA	4-semester continuing education certificate, approved by and issued through University of Georgia's Center on Continuing Education and Professional Development
Public 4-year Medium non-R1	Utah State University Eastern	Aggies Elevated – Eastern	2-year certificate of Proficiency in Integrated College and Community Studies, approved through and awarded by university and board of regents
Public 4-year Large R1	Utah State University – Logan (Main Campus)	Aggies Elevated	2-year certificate of Proficiency in Integrated College and Community Studies, approved through and awarded by university and board of regents
Public 4-year Large R1	University of Kansas	Transition to Postsecondary Education (TPE)	2-year certificate approved through and awarded by College of Education
Public 4-year Medium non-R1	University of Louisiana Lafayette	UL LIFE Program	Certificate of Accomplishment approved through the University of Louisiana College of Education and Human Development.
Private	Lipscomb University	Lipscomb IDEAL	2-year (48-hour) certificate of Career Exploration Studies, approved via curriculum committee, entered into system by registrar
Community College	Lehigh Carbon Community College	SEED [Success, Engagement, Education, Determination]	2-year certificate, approved through the college, awarded through Workforce Development department
Community College	Highline College	Achieve	2-year ACHIEVE certificate

“Moving an academic program through the Faculty Senate is not for the faint of heart. However, the benefit far outweighs the challenges. Engaging all departments and committees means that the program is more fully known, and it’s accepted as part of the vision for the university. I don’t think I can overstate how important that has been.” (Kate Strater, *A Credential Approval Journey: Calvin University*)

Each interviewee described a multi-step process, involving several different departments at the institution. They reported the culmination of the process is worth the effort, as students completing the program are awarded an official, recognized credential from the institution that has meaning, value, and rigor. They earn a postsecondary education credential that is like those earned by all other graduates at the institution.

All indicated they used the same process for approval of a new credential as any other program at the college or university would. They noted issues can arise around the unique aspects of a CTP program, such as auditing courses, that will need to be negotiated.

One or more of the directors interviewed shared the following tips for other programs seeking to obtain institutional approval for the program credential.

Work with all Relevant Departments at the IHE

Approval of a program certificate will require the partnership of several individuals and departments at your IHE. Because the program employs a program of study, the certificate will likely have to be approved as an academic credential. There is a process in place at each IHE to seek this approval.

While the details of the process may vary by college or university, there are several individuals who are critical to gaining approval in most every situation.

Key Partners in the Credential Approval Process

Department Chair/School Director

As the leader of an academic unit, they will be the first to sign off on new credentials or initiatives. They will likely have the most insight into how to frame a proposal and different considerations for the structure and content of the proposal.

Dean

The approval will move from the department chair/school director to the Dean, before heading to the Provost’s office. The Dean will seek information about how this credential fits into the “big picture” of what is offered within the college. Their approval and support are critical, as they will likely be called upon to champion the unique aspects of the program and proposal at the Provost level.

Provost

The Provost is the chief academic officer at the IHE. Their job is to ensure that all requests are aligned with the expectations and mission of the IHE. Their understanding of the program and intended outcomes and the feedback they receive from the Dean will go a long way in securing approval.

Academic Council/Faculty Senate

Often the last hurdle for approval is the Academic Council/Faculty Senate. Higher education employs a shared governance model, where final approval of new programs or credentials is granted by a body that represents the faculty instructing courses.

Program directors from Lehigh Carbon Community College and University of Kansas shared the importance of building and maintaining relationships with key partners.

Michelle Mitchell, Lehigh Carbon Community College highlighted the value of targeted networking:

“We hired someone specifically to lead the development process, which involved talking to [academic] divisions, faculty, administrators, and curriculum committees.”

Dana Lattin at University of Kansas emphasized leveraging established relationships to gain support:

“We ran it through the School of Education because you go with what you know and who you know. That helped us align our Credential with the registrar and financial aid systems.”

Timeline

Programs described a range of experiences with credential development timelines. Some integrated the credential development alongside the launch of a PSE program, while others faced delays as they refined their offerings or aligned with institutional standards. For instance, Michelle Mitchell shared that it took several years after their initial pilot to approve a credential:

“We needed to work out the kinks in our program first and really establish where students were at before designing something meaningful.”

In contrast, Misty Parsley at Lipscomb University shared a more streamlined experience:

“We knew from the start that we wanted an IHE-approved credential, so we made it a part of our program development from day one.”

Strategic Planning

Programs also identified some strategic planning, such as considering the role of industry alignment. Michelle Mitchell reported,

“We worked to ensure the credential wasn’t just academic but also meaningful for employers, creating additional courses to meet industry needs.”

Another aspect of strategic planning is to consider and plan to address possible barriers to the credential being approved. The programs we interviewed identified several possible barriers, including integrating credentials into institutional systems, overcoming resistance from collaborators, and addressing logistical challenges. For example, Liz Dimond at Utah State University Eastern shared the difficulties of dealing with incomplete approval processes:

“The credential was approved, but no one had taken the steps to integrate it into our system, which caused delays in implementation.”

Others mentioned the initial or sustained resistance of campus partners, like those in Registrar and Bursar offices who rely on established processes, to modify or deviate from those processes.

Ultimately, these programs underscored the importance of persistence, collaboration, and aligning credentials with both student needs and institutional priorities. The transformative potential of these credentials resonated across interviews. As Michelle Mitchell stated,

“This credential is about ensuring our students leave with something tangible that demonstrates their value to employers and society.”

Program directors shared numerous helpful considerations during interviews that offer a roadmap to other programs as they consider seeking institutional approval for their program’s credential:

- Clarify the purpose and structure of your course of study and articulate its alignment with student needs, institutional goals, and industry standards.
- Ensure that your course of study is aligned with approval requirements by learning the requirements for certificate programs at your institution.
- Familiarize yourself with the program approval process at your institution. For example, many IHEs will have a standard form you will need to complete to apply for program approval.
- Collaborate early with key players, such as faculty, registrars, financial aid, and administrators. Identify champions to advocate for the credential and address resistance.
- Engage with all university/college departments involved in the approval process.

- Be aware that financial viability may be a component of the approval process. It may involve providing a program budget and business plan that outlines your program's financial stability.
- The process may include letters of support from the community to reinforce the need for the program at the IHE.
- Courses developed specifically for your program may also need to go through a curriculum approval process to be included in an IHE-approved credential.
- While some programs experienced an expedited process, one program recommends planning for up to 12 months for the process to be completed, involving several hours per week for the staff involved to engage in planning and attending required meetings.

Additional Considerations

College students with intellectual disability may wish to pursue other types of credentials. One important outcome of a program credential is that it can serve as a first step in supporting students to pursue additional certifications, like industry-recognized credentials, other college/university approved credentials, or degrees. However, that does not diminish the value of the program credential on its own or as a means to prepare students for obtaining employment and a higher quality of life.

Program credentials represent the rigor and experiences that a student has successfully navigated to earn this designation. Credentials awarded by programs for students with intellectual disability should be thoughtfully constructed to provide a high-quality and rigorous education. Completing the steps to have the program credential approved through formal channels at the college or university ensures it has met certain standards and increases its value.

Resources

- [Industry Recognized Credentials in Inclusive Postsecondary Education programs for Students with Intellectual Disability](#)
- [What is a Credential? – Association for Career and Technical Education](#)
- [A Credential Approval Journey: Calvin University](#)
- [Articulating the Value of a Credential from a PSE Program for Students with Intellectual Disability](#)
- [Example of Grading Rubrics](#)
- [Higher Education Opportunity Act of 2008](#), Pub. L. No. 110-315, 122 Stat. 3078
- [The 2024 Guide to Accreditation for Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability](#) by the Think College National Coordinating Center Accreditation Workgroup and Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

CATE WEIR is a Project Coordinator for the Think College National Coordinating Center at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston.

CHELSEA VANHORN STINNETT is the Technical Assistance and Research Manager for Think College at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston.

MATTHEW MCCLELLAN is a Research Associate at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston.

BELKIS CHOISEUL-PRASLIN is a Research Associate at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our thanks to those agreeing to be interviewed for this brief:

University of Georgia

Program: Destination Dawgs: Inclusive Post-Secondary Education at UGA

Contact: Carol Britton Laws

Utah State University Eastern

Program: Aggies Elevated – Eastern

Contact: Liz Dimond

Utah State University – Logan (Main Campus)

Program: Aggies Elevated

Contact: Lindsay Thunell

University of Kansas

Program: Transition to Postsecondary Education (TPE)

Contact: Dana Lattin

University of Louisiana at Lafayette

Program: UL LIFE Program

Contact: Jade Viator

Lipscomb University

Program: Lipscomb IDEAL

Contact: Misty Parsley

Lehigh Carbon Community College

Program: SEED [Success, Engagement, Education, Determination]

Contact: Michelle Mitchell

Highline College

Program: Achieve

Contact: Julie Pollard

INSIGHT, Issue No. 66, 2025

This is a publication of the Think College National Coordinating Center at the Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston, funded by the US Department of Education, Office of Postsecondary Education (Grant No. P407C210001). The opinions contained in this document are those of the grantee and do not necessarily reflect those of the funders.

Recommended citation: Weir, C., VanHorn Stinnett, C., McClellan, M.L., Choiseul-Praslin, B. (2025). Guide to the program credential development and approval process. Think College Insight Brief, Issue No. 66. Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston.

